

style. Aldo says Russians tend to be dimwits. He talks about Russians the way small children might talk about a 10-year-old who can't get the hang of hopscotch.

Aldo insisted on finding out what I did for a living. I told him I was retired, but that just wouldn't do. Aldo and his Yugoslav friends had never managed to save a dinar. Only Aldo's \$110 monthly pension keeps him and Dozanka from starving. He could relate to my retiring at age 35 as much as a fourteenth-century Yugoslav peasant might relate to Einstein's special theory of relativity.

I finally explained that I had been a public accountant, worked hard, got lucky, and made some money. I told him I had retired at age 35 and lived off the interest on my savings, and that Vicki and I were in Yugoslavia doing research for a book on how others can do the same.

Aldo furrowed his brow. "So the book is a fantasy story?"

I said, "Not at all. In America you can quit work at any age if you have enough money."

Aldo said, "Capitalism. It's unfair for anyone to have so much money."

"But you're missing the point," I said. "The book talks to those who value time more than money. I propose a life centered on family, friends, and simple pleasures rather than on owning and consuming. Happiness comes from living the way you want to live, not from spending a lot of money."

This talk took place after several adult portions of white lightning had disappeared. The language barrier meant that neither of us could know how much the other was picking up. But Aldo convinced me that he had the idea when he told me the following Yugoslav folk tale:

Once upon a time a king and his entourage were passing through a valley when they heard a man singing. The full, joyous sound caught the king's attention. He ordered his servants to take him to the singer. They detoured and came upon a humble blacksmith. He was singing merrily as he worked over his glowing fire pit.